

Religion establishes the beliefs and rituals surrounding the sacred and provides meaning and significance to individuals' lives. The tenets of any given religion can have a far-reaching impact on the individuals within its faith community. For example, certain religions promote faith-based lifestyle directives (FBLDs), which urge believers to follow specific guidelines regarding their own behavior (eg, restrictions on diet and substance use) and their treatment of others (eg, mission work). Because these practices typically reflect the religious group's values, FBLDs are often an important expression of faith for the deeply religious.

One religious group with health-related FBLDs is the Seventh Day Adventist Church, which formed in the 1860s after early leaders broke away from established Protestant churches. Since its formal establishment, Seventh Day Adventist Church membership has grown from 3,500 to over 20 million worldwide. The Seventh Day Adventist Church advocates conservative religious teachings and a holistic approach to health and wellness; members are encouraged to pursue vegetarianism, exercise regularly, and avoid alcohol and tobacco.

Although FBLDs impact believers' personal choices and behaviors, they are also often meant to have an impact on others through the creation of social institutions such as schools and hospitals. For example, early Adventist leaders developed a health care system to serve the needs of the larger community, and members of the modern Adventist Church have continued to try to reduce health disparities worldwide by creating hospitals, clinics, and universities that provide health care and education services to underserved and developing communities.

Researchers from a variety of fields have examined health-related religious values and FBLDs. Epidemiological research has shown that believers from different religions who follow certain FBLDs (eg, abstaining from smoking and alcohol) experience lower rates of chronic illnesses (eg, heart disease and many types of cancer) than the general population. Sociologists have suggested that as a society increasingly relies on medical professionals, rather than clergy, as legitimate sources of guidance on lifestyle behaviors, membership in religious groups with values that are compatible with medicalization will continue to rise. Some hypothesize that this phenomenon accounts for the seemingly contradictory increase in membership in certain conservative religious groups with strict FBLDs, despite mainstream society becoming less religious.

Which prediction is compatible with the sociologists' assertion in the fourth paragraph? The increase of medicalization in society will result in medical professionals having:

- ☒ A. greater power and authority. [48%]
- ☐ B. reduced power and authority. [3%]
- ☐ C. greater authority, but with no effect on their power. [29%]
- ☐ D. greater power, but with no effect on their authority. [17%]

Correct

48% answered correctly

Explanation:

In sociology, **power** refers to the **ability to control** and **influence** others. **Authority** refers to whether others **believe** that the power is **legitimate**. There are three types of authority:

- Traditional authority comes from longstanding patterns in society (eg, a queen is seen as having legitimate power in a monarchy).
- Charismatic authority stems from the personal appeal and/or extraordinary claims of an individual (eg, Gandhi was seen as having legitimate power due to his ability to inspire people).
- Rational-legal authority arises from the professional position a person holds (eg, a physician is seen as having legitimate power due to extensive training).

Medicalization, the process of defining human behaviors or characteristics as medical conditions, often results from shifting attitudes, new scientific evidence, or new treatments. For example, menopause, a natural condition, is now viewed by some as a deficiency in hormones that can be treated with pharmaceuticals. Medicalization leads individuals to look to medical professionals as the experts in diagnosing, preventing, or treating such conditions.

As medicalization increases in a society, individuals will increasingly rely on medical professionals, rather than clergy, as legitimate sources of guidance on lifestyle behaviors. Therefore, medical professionals will have more power (ie, influence on people) *and* authority, as that power will be seen as legitimate.

(Choice B) Increasing medicalization will *increase*, not reduce, the power and authority of medical professionals.

(Choices C and D) As medicalization increases, both the power (the ability to influence people) and authority (power being perceived as legitimate) of medical professionals will increase.

Educational objective:

In sociology, power refers to the ability to influence and control others. Authority refers to whether others perceive that power as legitimate.

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